



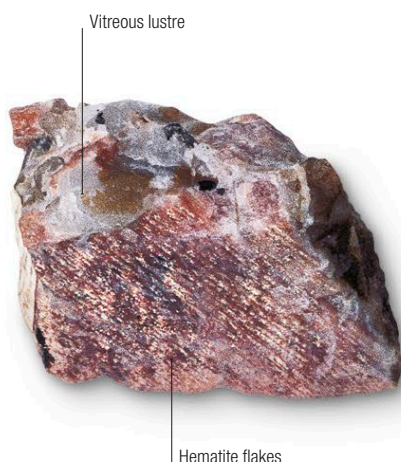
Sunstone

△ **Marquise-cut sunstone** sparkling with hematite inclusions

Sunstone is a gem that takes its name from its appearance, rather than as a result of the specific mineral it is made from. All types are characterized by minute, plate-like inclusions of iron oxide or copper, oriented parallel to one another, which give the stones a spangled appearance and often a reddish glow. The mineral classification of sunstones can be either oligoclase (a plagioclase feldspar) or orthoclase (an alkali feldspar). Other feldspars also produce sunstone in small quantities. Oligoclase sunstone is the most common type.

Specification

Chemical name Sodium, calcium aluminosilicate (oligoclase)
Formula $(\text{Na,Ca})\text{Al}_2\text{Si}_2\text{O}_8$ | **Colours** Grey, white, orange-brown, yellow | **Structure** Triclinic | **Hardness** 6.0–6.5
SG 2.62–2.65 | **RI** 1.53–1.55 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White | **Locations** USA, Norway, India, Canada, Russia



Vitreous lustre

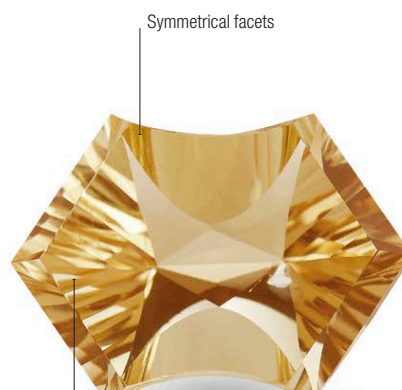
Hematite flakes

Oligoclase | Rough | This specimen of uncut oligoclase sunstone shows the platy inclusions of hematite in parallel lines that give the gem its typical warm glow.



Brilliant-cut facet

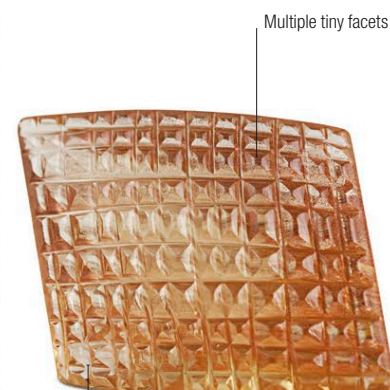
Fancy cut | Cut | This Oregon sunstone in the US national collection was faceted in a triangle cut by award-winning cutters Darryl Alexander and Aivan Pham.



Symmetrical facets

Multiple faces catch light and maximize glow

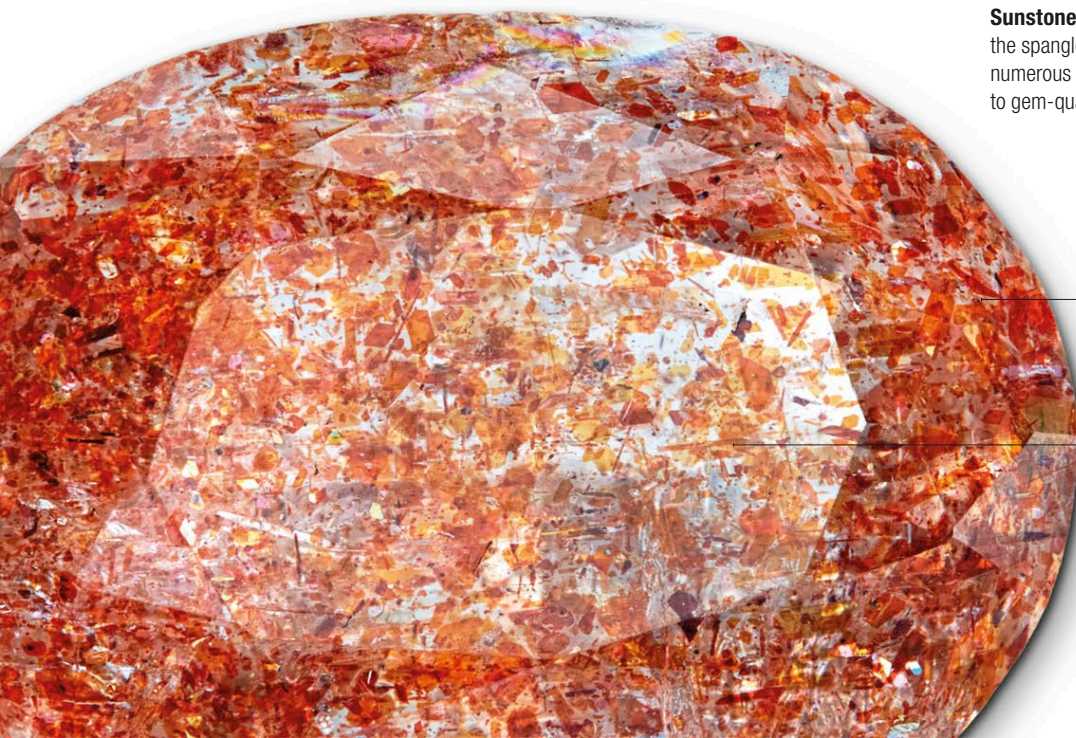
Virtuosopiece | Cut | The versatility of sunstone in the hands of a master cutter is shown by this piece entitled "Snowflake", cut by jewellery artist Darryl Alexander.



Multiple tiny facets

Play of light and shade gives appearance of depth

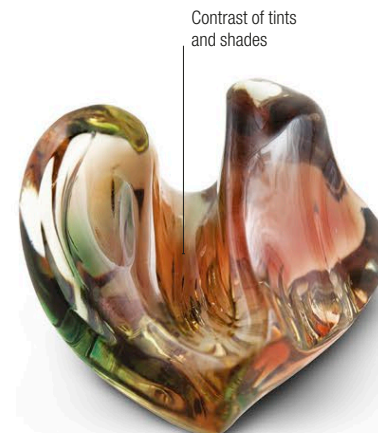
Fancy cut | Cut | Oregon, USA, is the source of much gem-quality oligoclase. This Oregon sunstone with copper inclusions was faceted by the renowned cutter Larry Winn.



Sunstone | Cut | This faceted oval shows the spangled appearance created by the numerous inclusions that raise the mineral to gem-quality grade.

Densely clustered inclusions

Transparent surface between inclusions



Contrast of tints and shades

Heart shape | Carved | This piece of sunstone from Oregon was carved into a heart by American Naomi Sarna, who specializes in sculptural gem-cutting.